

The Department for Science, Innovation and Technology (DSIT) was a ministerial department of the government of the United Kingdom. It was established on 7 February 2023 by a cabinet reshuffle under the Rishi Sunak premiership.

The department took on policy responsibilities from the former Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy (BEIS) and the Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport (DCMS). The new department was responsible for helping to encourage, develop and manage the UK's scientific, research, and technological outputs. DSIT was also responsible for managing the necessary physical and digital infrastructure and regulation to support the British economy, UK public services, national security, and wider UK Government priorities.

The department was led by the Secretary of State for Science, Innovation and Technology, supported by a number of junior ministers, and senior civil servants. The final secretary of state was Liz Kendall.

The department was disbanded at the start of the Burnham ministry on 20 July 2026, with the majority of responsibilities reverting to the Department for Business and Trade and the Department for Culture, Media and Sport. The Government Digital Service, which had previously been part of the Cabinet Office, was moved to DCMS, with some responsibilities relating to artificial intelligence being moved to the Cabinet Office.

History

The department was established on 7 February 2023 after a cabinet reshuffle by Prime Minister Rishi Sunak. It absorbed some of the functions and responsibilities of the former Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy (BEIS) and the 'Digital' portfolio from the former Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport (DCMS). The new department's first Secretary of State, Michelle Donelan, was the final Secretary of State for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport. Additionally, the new department became responsible for a number of agencies and offices drawn from across the rest of the UK Government. These included the

Government Office for Science (formerly under BEIS), the Office for Science and Technology Strategy (formerly of the Cabinet Office), the Office for Life Sciences (jointly with the Department of Health and Social Care (DHSC), formerly a BEIS-DHSC joint unit) and the Office for Artificial Intelligence (formerly of the Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport).

Responsibilities

The following responsibilities of DSIT were outlined by Rishi Sunak upon the department's establishment in 2023.

Research and innovation

DSIT was responsible for positioning the UK at the forefront of global scientific and technological advancement. It was intended for the department to drive innovation that changes lives and sustains economic growth. It was intended to do this by maintaining and developing the physical and digital infrastructure and regulation necessary to support the UK economy and public services, and UK national security.

Another stated responsibility of the department was to put British public services, including the NHS and schools at the forefront of innovation, championing new ways of working (with an express focus on STEM subjects to improve outcomes for people).

DSIT was further responsible for managing the UK Government's Research and Development schemes, aiming to optimise public investment to support areas of relative UK strength and increase the level of private investment in an effort to make the UK economy the "most innovative" in the world. Moreover, DSIT was charged with promoting a diverse research and innovation system that connected discovery to new companies, growth and jobs – including by delivering world-class physical and digital infrastructure. This was with the professed intention of making the UK the "best place" to start and grow a technology business or to develop and attract "top talent". DSIT also functioned as a means of strengthening international

collaboration on science and technology in line with the findings of the 2021 Integrated Review, and to ensure that British researchers were able to continue to work with leading scientists in Europe and around the world.

International Science Partnerships Fund

DSIT funded and supported multiple bilateral and multilateral international science initiatives through its International Science Partnerships Fund (ISPF). These programmes were administered in collaboration with UK Research and Innovation (UKRI), the British Council, and various international partner governments and institutions. Programme's funded by the ISPF included the UK–France Researcher Mobility Scheme which supported short-term visits by UK-based researchers to France and supported collaboration in Horizon Europe priority areas such as artificial intelligence, energy transition, and Earth observation. Another ISPF funded programme was the UK–Israel Research Collaboration, which was jointly supported by DSIT and Israel's Ministry of Innovation, Science and Technology (MOST). It provided £1.8 million (NIS 9 million) to promote joint research on shared priorities, and offered grants of up to £200,000 for collaborative teams in both countries. DSIT also supported several partnerships in advanced technologies with the United States through ISPF, including the US–UK Artificial Intelligence for Realistic Science, Global Centers on Clean Energy and Climate Change, and the US–UK Quantum Science & Technologies programme. These initiatives were supported by UKRI and partner US institutions.

Legislation and regulation

On a legislative and regulatory level, DSIT was responsible for delivering key legislative and regulatory reforms to drive competition and promote innovation. This included completing the passage of new digital and data laws. DSIT was also responsible for leading the UK Government's pro-innovation approach to regulating AI.

Ministers

At the time of the department's disbandment in 2026, its ministerial team was as follows, with cabinet ministers in bold:

The department's ministers were supported by the department's civil servants under the leadership of a Permanent Secretary. The incumbent Permanent Secretary was Emran Mian.

The Government Chief Scientific Adviser was also attached to the department, and holds the rank of Permanent Secretary. The incumbent Chief Scientific Adviser was Dame Angela McLean.

The National Technology Advisor was also based within the department.

Agencies and public bodies

The following agencies and public bodies were sponsored by DSIT.

Executive agencies

Intellectual Property Office

Met Office

Executive non-departmental public bodies

Advanced Research and Invention Agency

Information Commissioner's Office

UK Research and Innovation

Tribunals

Copyright Tribunal

Public corporations

National Physical Laboratory

Ordnance Survey

Other

British Technology Investments

Building Digital UK (BDUK)

Government Digital Service

Government Office for Science

Ofcom

Office for Life Sciences (OLS)

Regulatory Innovation Office (RIO)

UK Shared Business Services

UK Space Agency

Former

Central Digital and Data Office

Incubator for Artificial Intelligence

Phone-paid Services Authority

See also

Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport (2017–2023) – from which DSIT absorbed the digital portfolio.

Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy (2016–2023) – defunct department from which DSIT inherited various responsibilities

Department for Innovation, Universities and Skills (2007–2009) – a defunct UK government department with a similar overall purpose.

Ministry of Technology (1964–1970) – an historic UK government department with similar responsibilities.

Department of Scientific and Industrial Research (1916–1965) – a historic UK government department with similar responsibilities.

References

External links

Official website

Making Government Deliver: Updating the machinery of government for the world of today and of tomorrow (policy paper forwarded by Rishi Sunak explaining the rationale for the department)